[Resilience X

Travel and Expense Reimbursement Policy

Effective Date: January 1, 2024
Version: 1.0
Approved By: Chief Financial Officer

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1.0 Introduction

1.1 Purpose and Guiding Principles

This policy provides the framework for all employees of [Resilience X who travel for business purposes. Its purpose is to ensure that travel is properly authorized, cost-effective, and safe, and that expenses incurred are reimbursed in a fair, consistent, and timely manner.

Our guiding principles are:

- **Stewardship: We are all stewards of the company's resources. Travel and expense decisions should be made with the same prudence as if you were spending your own money.**
- **Safety and Well-being: The safety and security of our travelers is a top priority.**
- **Efficiency: Our processes and tools are designed to make booking travel and submitting expenses as simple as possible.**
- **Clarity: This policy aims to provide clear and unambiguous guidelines to prevent confusion and ensure fairness.**

1.2 Scope and Applicability

This policy applies to all regular full-time and part-time employees, as well as any authorized non-employees (such as job candidates, consultants, and contractors) who are approved to travel on behalf of [Resilience X.

1.3 Employee Responsibility as a Steward of Company Resources

When you travel for business, you are representing [Resilience X. We trust you to make sound, responsible financial decisions. This includes booking travel in advance to secure lower prices, choosing reasonably priced meals and accommodations, and protecting company assets. This policy provides the necessary guidelines, but sound personal judgment is paramount.

1.4 Key Definitions

- **Business Travel: Any travel undertaken by an employee to a location more than 50 miles/80 kilometers from their primary office or home office for the purpose of conducting company business.**
- **Corporate Travel Platform: The company's official online booking tool and designated travel management company (TMC) for all air, hotel, and car rental reservations.**

- **Corporate Credit Card: A company-issued credit card intended for business-related travel and entertainment expenses.**
- **Reimbursable Expense: A necessary and reasonable out-of-pocket expense incurred by an employee while conducting business travel, which is eligible for repayment by the company.**
- **Itemized Receipt: A receipt that details the vendor, transaction date, items purchased, amount of each item, and total amount paid. A credit card summary slip is not an itemized receipt.**

2.0 Travel Authorization and Booking

2.1 Pre-Travel Authorization

All business travel, regardless of cost, must be approved in advance.

1. **Employees must submit a "Travel Request" (TR) through the corporate expense system before making any travel arrangements.**
2. **The TR must include the business purpose of the trip, estimated dates, destination, and an estimated breakdown of costs (airfare, hotel, meals, etc.).**
3. **The TR will be electronically routed to the employee's direct manager for approval. For international travel or trips exceeding a certain cost threshold (e.g., $5,000), secondary approval from the department head is required.**
4. **Booking of travel must not commence until the TR has been fully approved.**

2.2 Booking Procedures: Using the Corporate Travel Platform

To ensure we can leverage our corporate discounts and fulfill our duty of care, all air travel, hotel accommodations, and rental car reservations must be booked through the company's designated Corporate Travel Platform. Booking outside the official platform is a policy violation and may result in non-reimbursement, unless a valid exception is pre-approved in writing.

2.3 Use of the Corporate Credit Card

Employees who travel frequently for business are expected to obtain and use a company-issued Corporate Credit Card.

- **The Corporate Credit Card should be used for all major travel expenses, including airfare, hotels, rental cars, and business meals.**
- **Using the card simplifies expense reporting, as transactions are automatically fed into the expense management system.**
- **The employee is responsible for submitting timely expense reports to pay off the card balance. The card is the employee's financial responsibility; failure to submit expense reports may impact the employee's credit score.**
- **Personal use of the Corporate Credit Card is strictly prohibited.**

2.4 Travel for Non-Employees (Candidates, Contractors)

For non-employees, travel arrangements must be booked by their internal host or an administrative assistant through the Corporate Travel Platform. Non-employees will not be issued a Corporate Credit Card and will be reimbursed for out-of-pocket expenses after submitting a valid expense report with receipts.

2.5 Case Example: Planning and Authorizing a Business Trip

- **Scenario: David needs to travel to London for a 3-day client workshop.**
- **Action:**
    1. **Two months before the trip, David creates a Travel Request in the expense system. He lists the purpose, dates, and estimates his costs: Airfare (~$1,500), Hotel (3 nights @ ~$300/night), and Meals (3 days @ ~$100/day). Total estimated cost: $2,700.**
    2. **The TR is automatically sent to his manager, who reviews the business justification and estimated cost, and approves it.**
    3. **Once approved, David receives a notification. He then logs into the Corporate Travel Platform to book his flight and hotel, charging them to his Corporate Credit Card.**

3.0 Air Travel

3.1 Class of Service

The authorized class of air service is determined by the total flight time (including layovers).

Flight Duration	Authorized Class of Service
Under 8 hours (Domestic/International)	Economy / Coach Class
8 hours or more (International only)	Premium Economy or Business Class

Travelers are expected to book the lowest logical airfare available within the authorized class of service. "Lowest logical airfare" allows for a minor cost difference (e.g., up to $200) to secure a more convenient flight (e.g., non-stop vs. one-stop, preferred airline).

3.2 Booking in Advance

To secure the best prices, flights must be booked at least 14 days prior to the travel date. Booking within 14 days requires written justification in the booking tool.

3.3 Ancillary Fees and Upgrades

- **Reimbursable:**
    - **Standard seat selection fees.**
    - **Fee for one checked bag per flight segment.**
    - **In-flight Wi-Fi when there is a documented business need to work during the flight.**
- **Not Reimbursable:**
    - **Upgrades to a higher class of service beyond what is permitted by this policy.**

    - "Economy Plus" or similar seats with extra legroom on flights under 8 hours.
    - Priority boarding fees.
    - Airline club memberships or day passes.
    - In-flight entertainment or refreshments (these should be part of the meal per diem).

3.4 Frequent Flyer and Loyalty Programs

Employees are encouraged to join frequent flyer and other loyalty programs. You may retain any points or status earned from business travel. However, travel decisions must be based on cost-effectiveness and policy, not on the desire to earn loyalty points with a specific airline or hotel chain.

3.5 Cancellations and Changes

If business plans change, the company will cover the cost of changing or canceling a flight. If a trip is canceled, you must ensure any unused ticket credit is applied to future business travel. Fees incurred for changes or cancellations made for personal convenience are not reimbursable.

3.6 Case Example: Selecting a Cost-Effective Flight

- Scenario: Sarah is booking a flight to Chicago. The Corporate Travel Platform shows two options:
    - Option A: $350 on a budget airline with a 6 AM departure.
    - Option B: $425 on a preferred airline with a 9 AM departure.
- Analysis: Option B is the "lowest logical airfare." The early departure of Option A would require Sarah to travel to the airport at an unreasonable hour. The modest cost difference is justified for a more reasonable schedule that does not negatively impact productivity.

4.0 Ground Transportation

4.1 Rental Cars

- Booking: Must be booked through the Corporate Travel Platform using our preferred rental partners.
- Vehicle Class: The standard authorized vehicle class is Intermediate / Mid-size. Larger vehicles require a business justification (e.g., traveling with multiple colleagues or equipment).
- Insurance: When renting a car for business in the United States, you must decline the Collision Damage Waiver (CDW) / Loss Damage Waiver (LDW) and additional liability insurance, as the company's corporate insurance policy provides this coverage. For international rentals, you must accept this insurance.
- Fuel: Pre-paying for a full tank of fuel from the rental agency is not reimbursable. The car should be refueled before being returned, and the actual fuel cost is reimbursable.

4.2 Use of Personal Vehicles

Employees may use their personal vehicle for business travel, typically for shorter distances where it is more cost-effective than flying or renting a car.

- **Reimbursement: Mileage is reimbursed at the standard rate set by the local tax authority (e.g., the IRS rate in the U.S.). This rate covers the cost of fuel, insurance, maintenance, and depreciation.**
- **Cost Cap: Total mileage reimbursement for a trip cannot exceed the cost of the lowest logical airfare for the same trip.**
- **Fuel and Insurance: Fuel is not separately reimbursable when claiming mileage. Your personal auto insurance serves as the primary coverage.**

4.3 Taxis, Ride-Sharing, and Car Services

- **Taxis and ride-sharing services (e.g., UberX, Lyft) are the preferred methods for local transportation.**
- **Use of premium services (e.g., Uber Black, luxury car services) is not permitted unless there is a valid business reason (e.g., transporting clients) and it is pre-approved.**

4.4 Public Transportation and Airport Shuttles

The use of cost-effective public transportation (subways, buses, trains) and hotel/airport shuttles is strongly encouraged wherever safe and practical.

4.5 Case Example: Choosing the Right Ground Transportation

- **Scenario: Ken is in New York City for two days of meetings in Manhattan.**
- **Analysis: Renting a car would be impractical and expensive due to traffic and high parking costs.**
- **Correct Action: Ken should use the subway for most travel and supplement with taxis or ride-sharing for specific trips where public transport is not convenient. This is the most cost-effective and efficient approach.**

5.0 Accommodations

5.1 Hotel Reservations

All hotel accommodations must be booked through the Corporate Travel Platform to ensure access to negotiated rates and for traveler safety tracking.

5.2 Hotel Rate Guidelines

Employees are expected to book standard rooms at reasonably priced, business-appropriate hotels. The company has established nightly rate caps based on the travel market.

Market Tier	Major Cities (Examples)	Nightly Rate Cap (USD)
Tier 1	New York City, San Francisco, London	$400

Market Tier	Major Cities (Examples)	Nightly Rate Cap (USD)
Tier 2	Chicago, Boston, Amsterdam	$300
Tier 3	All other domestic/international cities	$225

These caps are guidelines. If the designated conference hotel or the only safe/available hotels are above the cap, this can be approved with justification.

5.3 Non-Hotel Accommodations (e.g., Airbnb)

Booking accommodations such as Airbnb or other home-sharing services requires pre-approval from both the employee's manager and the HR department. Approval will only be granted for long-term stays (over 7 nights) or in situations where it is significantly more cost-effective than a hotel.

5.4 Reimbursable vs. Non-Reimbursable Hotel Charges

- **Reimbursable: Room rate, associated taxes, and high-speed internet access fees.**
- **Not Reimbursable: Mini-bar charges, in-room movies or entertainment, gym or spa fees, laundry (unless the trip exceeds 5 consecutive nights), and other personal incidental expenses.**

5.5 Case Example: Booking a Conference Hotel Above the Rate Cap

- **Scenario: Maria is attending a mandatory conference in San Francisco (Tier 1 city, $400 cap). The conference hotel rate is $450/night. Other policy-compliant hotels are a 20-minute taxi ride away.**
- **Analysis: While the conference hotel is over the guideline, staying there offers significant benefits in terms of networking, convenience, and saving on daily transportation costs.**
- **Correct Action: Maria should select the conference hotel and add a comment in her booking: "Selected designated conference hotel for business convenience and to save on ground transportation costs." This justification will be reviewed and approved by her manager.**

6.0 Meals and Entertainment

6.1 Employee Meals While Traveling

Instead of a fixed per diem, the company will reimburse the actual costs of meals, up to a daily limit, while on business travel.

- **The daily limit for an employee's meals (breakfast, lunch, and dinner) is $100 USD for domestic travel and $125 USD for international travel.**

- **This limit is not a per diem; you will only be reimbursed for what you actually spend. Itemized receipts are required for all meals.**
- **The limit is intended to cover the food, tax, and tip.**

6.2 Business Meals with External Parties (Clients, Partners)

When dining with an external business contact, the meal cost is a reimbursable entertainment expense and is not subject to the employee meal limits. However, the cost must be reasonable and appropriate for the business context.

- **You must submit an itemized receipt.**
- **In the expense report, you must list the names of all attendees, their company affiliations, and the specific business purpose of the meal.**

6.3 Team Meals with Internal Colleagues

When two or more employees traveling together dine out, one employee should pay for the meal and submit it for reimbursement, listing the other employees as attendees. This prevents multiple employees from claiming expenses for the same meal.

6.4 Policy on Alcohol

The cost of a moderate amount of alcohol with a meal is reimbursable. The general guideline is a maximum of two standard drinks per person with a dinner meal. Excessive alcohol consumption will not be reimbursed.

6.5 Non-Reimbursable Meals

The company will not reimburse meals that are:

- **Included in a conference registration fee.**
- **Provided by an airline or hotel (e.g., complimentary breakfast).**
- **Incurred within 50 miles of your primary office or home.**

6.6 Case Example: Submitting Meal Expenses for a Trip

- **Scenario: Frank is on a one-day trip to Boston. He spends $15 on breakfast, $25 on lunch, and $55 on dinner with a client.**
- **Action:**
    1. **In his expense report, he submits the $15 breakfast and $25 lunch receipts against his individual meal allowance. Total: $40, which is under the $100 daily limit.**
    2. **For the $55 dinner, he submits it as a "Business Entertainment" expense. He attaches the itemized receipt and adds a comment: "Dinner with Jane Smith from Acme Corp to discuss Q4 project plan."**

7.0 Other Reimbursable Expenses

7.1 Communication Expenses

- **Mobile Phone: The use of your personal mobile phone for business calls and data is covered by the company's monthly mobile phone stipend. Additional roaming charges for international travel may be reimbursed with manager approval.**
- **Hotel Internet: Standard high-speed internet in your hotel room is reimbursable.**

7.2 Laundry and Dry Cleaning

For domestic travel exceeding five (5) consecutive nights and international travel exceeding three (3) consecutive nights, reasonable laundry and dry-cleaning expenses are reimbursable.

7.3 Gratuities (Tips)

Reasonable and customary tips for services (e.g., housekeeping, bellhops, valets) are reimbursable. A general guideline is:

- **Housekeeping: $3-5 per night.**
- **Bellhop/Porter: $2 per bag.**
- **Valet: $2-5 when retrieving your car.**

7.4 Passports and Visas

The company will reimburse the cost of obtaining or renewing passports and any necessary business visas for employees who are required to travel internationally for their jobs.

7.5 Currency Conversion

When you submit expenses in a foreign currency, the expense management system will automatically convert them to your home currency based on the rate at the time of the transaction. Foreign transaction fees charged by your credit card are reimbursable.

7.6 A Comprehensive List of Non-Reimbursable Expenses

This list is not exhaustive, but provides clear examples of personal expenses that will not be reimbursed:

- **Airline club memberships or passes**
- **Annual fees for personal credit cards**
- **Barbers, hairdressers, or personal grooming**
- **Childcare or pet-sitting services**
- **Clothing or toiletries**
- **Commuting between home and your primary office**
- **Corporate card delinquency fees or finance charges**
- **Country club or athletic club dues**
- **In-room movies, mini-bar purchases, or video games**
- **Loss or theft of personal property (e.g., cash, luggage)**
- **Medical expenses or prescriptions**

- **Optional travel insurance**
- **Parking tickets or traffic violations**
- **Personal reading material (magazines, books)**
- **Souvenirs or personal gifts**
- **Spa or fitness center fees**

8.0 Expense Reporting and Reimbursement

8.1 Timely Submission

Expense reports must be submitted within 30 days of the completion of a trip or the date an expense was incurred. Submitting reports in a timely manner is critical for accurate financial accounting and for paying Corporate Credit Card balances.

8.2 Receipt and Documentation Requirements

- **An itemized receipt is required for any single expense of $25.00 or more.**
- **For lodging, you must provide the itemized hotel folio, not just the credit card slip.**
- **For air travel, the flight itinerary showing the ticket number and total cost is required.**
- **All receipts must be legible and clearly show the vendor, date, and amount.**

8.3 Submitting an Expense Report

All expense reports must be created and submitted through the company's online expense management system. Corporate Credit Card transactions will populate automatically; out-of-pocket expenses must be entered manually.

8.4 Approval Workflow

Once submitted, the expense report is routed to your direct manager for review and approval. The manager is responsible for verifying that the expenses are reasonable, compliant with policy, and have a valid business purpose. After manager approval, the report is routed to the Finance department for a final audit.

8.5 Reimbursement Timeline

Reimbursements for approved out-of-pocket expenses will be paid via direct deposit within 10 business days of the report's final approval by the Finance department.

8.6 Case Example: Lost or Missing Receipt

- **Scenario: Susan paid $40 in cash for a taxi and lost the receipt.**
- **Correct Action: For expenses under a certain threshold (e.g., $75), a missing receipt affidavit can be used. Susan should manually enter the expense in the system, and when prompted for a receipt, she must select the "Missing Receipt" option and provide a detailed written explanation of the expense. This should be done sparingly and is subject to manager scrutiny.**

9.0 Special Travel Situations

9.1 International Travel

Employees traveling internationally are responsible for ensuring they have a valid passport and any necessary visas. You should consult with your doctor regarding any recommended immunizations. Be aware of your surroundings and follow all company travel security advisories.

9.2 Conferences, Seminars, and Trade Shows

When attending a conference, the registration fee is a reimbursable expense. If the fee includes certain meals, you may not claim reimbursement for those same meals separately.

9.3 Combining Personal and Business Travel ("Bleisure")

We encourage a healthy work-life balance and permit employees to extend business trips for personal vacation time.

- **Approval: You must indicate your intent to take personal days on your initial Travel Request.**
- **Airfare: To determine the reimbursable portion of your airfare, you must obtain a "cost comparison" flight itinerary from the Corporate Travel Platform at the time of booking. This comparison should show the cost of a round-trip flight for the business-only portion of your trip. The company will reimburse up to the amount of this comparison flight. Any additional cost for the modified itinerary is the employee's personal expense.**
- **Other Expenses: The company will not reimburse any expenses (hotel, meals, transport) incurred on personal days.**

9.4 Case Example: Expense Reporting for a Combined Business/Personal Trip

- **Scenario: Chen is traveling to Paris for business from Monday to Friday and wants to stay for the weekend for a vacation, returning on Sunday.**
- **Action:**
    1. **At the time of booking, Chen gets a cost comparison for a flight that returns on Friday. The cost is €1,200. His actual flight, returning on Sunday, costs €1,350. The company will reimburse him for €1,200; the remaining €150 is his personal cost.**
    2. **He submits expenses for his hotel from Monday night to Thursday night, his meals from Monday to Friday, and his ground transport during the business days.**
    3. **He does not submit any expenses for his hotel, meals, or activities on Saturday or Sunday.**

10.0 Traveler Safety and Security

10.1 Duty of Care

While the company takes every measure to ensure your safety, you also have a responsibility to exercise good judgment and be aware of your surroundings. Avoid risky situations and locations.

10.2 Emergency Assistance

The company subscribes to a global emergency assistance provider. Before any international travel, you will be provided with a membership card and 24/7 contact numbers for medical, security, or travel emergencies.

10.3 Travel Alerts

Employees are expected to register their international trips with our travel security provider to receive real-time alerts and advisories for their destination.

11.0 Policy Compliance and Exceptions

11.1 Compliance and Audits

Compliance with this policy is mandatory. All expense reports are subject to audit by the Finance department. Violations of this policy may result in delayed reimbursement, non-reimbursement of expenses, or disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment.

11.2 Requesting an Exception

We recognize that exceptions to this policy may sometimes be necessary. Any request for an exception must be made in writing and be pre-approved by your manager and the Vice President of your department before the expense is incurred.

12.0 Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1: Do I need a receipt for every single purchase?
A: A receipt is required for any expense of $25 or more. While not required for smaller items, it is still best practice to obtain receipts for everything.

Q2: I booked my hotel outside the Corporate Travel Platform because I found a cheaper rate. Will it be reimbursed?
A: Booking outside the platform is a policy violation. While the cost savings are appreciated, our policy is mandatory to ensure traveler safety and access to corporate benefits. This expense may not be reimbursed without prior written approval for an exception.

Q3: Can I be reimbursed for buying a gift for a client?
A: Client gifts must be pre-approved by your manager and must comply with our company's separate Gift & Entertainment Policy. They should not be submitted as a standard travel expense.

Q4: My flight was canceled and I had to stay an extra night. Are the additional costs covered?
A: Yes. The cost of an additional night's lodging and meals due to airline-controlled cancellations or weather delays is reimbursable.

Q5: What is the difference between a Travel Request and an Expense Report?
A: A Travel Request is a pre-trip authorization and cost estimate. An Expense Report is a post-trip submission of actual, incurred expenses for reimbursement.

13.0 Revision History

Version	Date of Revision	Summary of Changes	Approved By
1.0	Jan 1, 2024	Initial release of the comprehensive Travel and Expense Reimbursement Policy.	Chief Financial Officer